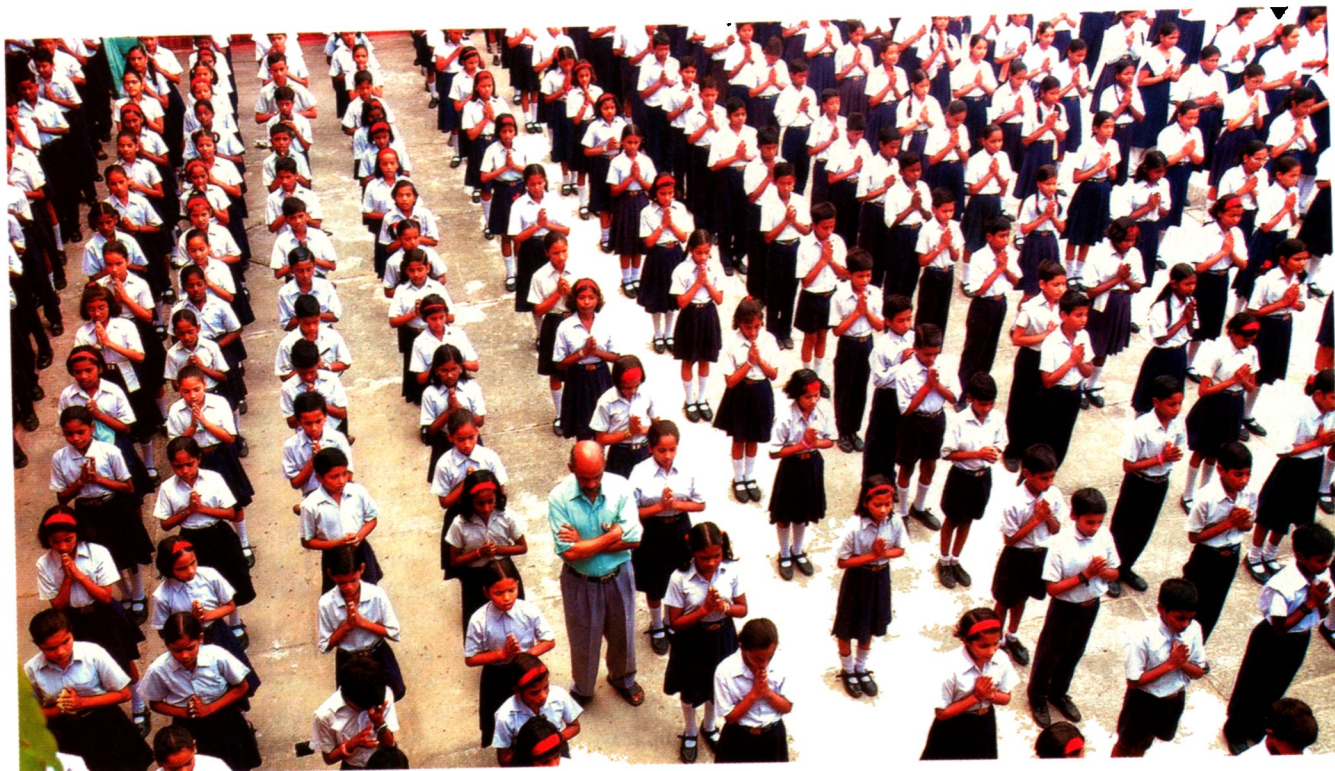




SCHOOL OF THOUGHT: *Vande Mataram* symbolises invocation of a nation-goddess

tural in ways that go well beyond what Britain experiences today. This too is a consequence of diverse historical processes from migrations and invasions to the proliferation of social and religious movements that transformed existing societies and gave rise to new communities. The subcontinent has historically become home not only to a truly staggering array of languages and spiritual creeds, but also myriad literary, intellectual, musical and artistic traditions as well as diverse political philosophies, economic systems and ways of living. Faced with the challenge, from the late 19th century onwards, of imagining the emergence of a single political entity out of this daunting heterogeneity, early nationalists understood immediately that homogenising models of unification were doomed to failure. India, the modern nation, would have to be different from the relatively monolithic European models on offer. Unity, yes, but with many a difference.

It is instructive in this context to revisit the controversy that periodically flares up, prompted by the Hindutva brigade, about whether *Vande Mataram* should replace *Jana Gana Mana* as the national anthem. The latter was written by Tagore and sung at a 1911 Congress session at a time when the idea of a heterogeneous new nation-state was starting to take shape. The Sangh Parivar, however, has chosen to perpetuate the hopeful colonial myth that it was intended to fe-

Our national anthem maps a diverse terrain while *Vande Mataram*, still the national song, offers prayers to a single figure imaged as a mother commanding fervent devotion.

licitate King George V. *Vande Mataram*, on the other hand, was the rallying cry for the Santans, a fictional Hindu monastic order in Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's novel, *Ananda Math*, which tells the story of their uprising against a venal Muslim ruler. As many have noted then and since, Tagore's hymn to the 'dispenser of India's destiny' was, after much debate, found to be more suitable to a multi-faith society than Bankim's powerful invocation of a nation-goddess modelled on Durga and worshipped in the Hindu manner. Our national anthem maps a geographically and linguistically diverse terrain while *Vande Mataram*, still the national song, offers prayers to a single figure imaged as a mother commanding fervent devotion.

In themselves, both lyrics could be regarded as fairly innocuous works, reflecting different historical and literary moments, even different modes of worship. But it is no accident that the